REPRODUCING BALL LIGHTNING

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Editor, QST:

My brother and I have been interested in building and operating some large Oudin and Tesla coils, more for the spectacular effect than anything else. While tuning up one large Oudin coil (stands about 4 feet) we had it grounded to the steam heating pipes of the building which passed directly behind the coil. The power was operated by our radio key, in fact the radio transmitting set was used. My young brother was standing with his right hand on the key and with his left, fingers up, palm extended, towards the large copper ball on top of the coil. Before he had moved his hand close enough to receive the discharge from the ball a "spark" or "fireball" broke from the STEAM PIPES, passed within about 12" of the copper ball and struck the boy on the palm. He received quite a jolt from this but nothing serious. Later he lost the skin from the palm of his hand. I could not get a good look at the "fireball" from where I was standing. We thought the matter was more of a joke than anything else and paid no attention to what really had happened.

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Sometime later we had moved the coil several feet from the pipes and were again operating it. This time I was operating the key with the boy looking on. Another spark of "fireball" came, this time from the copper ball on top of the coil, and passed directly towards the boy, striking him in the forehead. He received nothing worse than a bad headache from this one. I was standing so that I had a clear view of the entire action. The ball appeared to be about $\frac{3}{16}$ inches in diameter, very white, and was sparkling. It traveled fairly slowly, that is, so we could see it plainly, but a little too fast for the boy to dodge well. Now I would like to know what these things were—has anyone else seen anything like them? I cannot understand why they should ignore closer objects and people and pick on that brother of mine. Maybe they do not like him.

Any assistance you can give me will be very much appreciated.

Yours very truly,
Benj. F. Painter.